

You're about to say something you'll regret

7 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 7 sources · [cheatgrid.com](#)

You're angry right now, right in front of whoever caused it, phone in hand or the words already forming. It feels like saying this is the only way to make the feeling stop.

THE GOAL

You're trying to get through the next few minutes without doing something that costs you more than this moment is worth.

CHECKLIST

The moment right before you speak or hit send: phone in hand, or the words already forming.

- ☐ Stop right where you are: stop talking mid-sentence or stop typing, and don't send anything yet.
- ☐ Put the phone face down or step back half a pace so your hands are empty.
- ☐ Take slow breaths and let your shoulders and jaw unclench, until your breathing evens out.
- ☐ Put a name to what's behind this anger, then check whether it's really about this or something else that followed you in.
- ☐ Sort yourself: are you still face to face, on a call with them, or is this a message you haven't sent yet?
- ☐ If you're face to face or on a call, say it out loud: 'I need a few minutes before I say something I'll regret.'
- ☐ If it's a message, delete it and send one line that buys time instead: 'I want to reply properly, give me a bit.'
- ☐ Step away for the length of a break you set yourself, say twenty minutes, or until you're back from a walk.
- ☐ While you're away, do something absorbing, like a walk. If your mind drifts back to what set you off, switch to something that holds it.
- ☐ Check whether you're calm enough now to speak or reply; if not, take another break the same length first.
- ☐ Pick the one sentence that says what you want, like 'I need this fixed by Friday,' not the whole case you'd otherwise make.
- ☐ Say the one thing you actually want them to know, plainly, before anything else.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Your anger pulls your read on this toward yourself. It makes the other person's view less reachable.
- 2 You're sure you'll always feel this way. It's common to end up calm after an argument and unable to explain why you were that angry.
- 3 Replaying it in your head doesn't help you calm down faster. In the study behind this, people who kept dwelling on who'd angered them stayed angrier than people who deliberately thought about something else instead.

What your anger is hiding from you

KNOW

Your anger pulls your read on this toward yourself. It makes the other person's view less reachable.

Anger makes your body more keyed up, which **narrows your focus** onto your own side of it. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

You're sure you'll always feel this way. It's common to end up calm after an argument and unable to explain why you were that angry.

Being angry stops you from accurately judging how you'll feel once it passes. [Source 4](#)

What actually calms you down

DON'T

You want the rush of venting, not to fix anything. Researchers say that's what **trains you to repeat it**.

Feeling good afterward makes a behavior stick, so you repeat it instead of dealing with what caused it. [Source 1](#)

DON'T

A hard workout doesn't cool you down. A large review found jogging made anger worse, not better.

The same review measured how keyed-up the body gets, and only calming it down lowered anger. [Source 1](#)

DON'T

Replaying it in your head doesn't help you calm down faster. In the study behind this, people who kept dwelling on who'd angered them stayed angrier than people who deliberately thought about something else instead.

Dwelling on it keeps aggressive thoughts primed and linked in your mind, while thinking about something else doesn't feed that same network. [Source 2](#)

What this moment costs you, and what it doesn't

KNOW

A sharp comment costs more than a good moment can undo. It usually takes **about five good ones**, research suggests.

This ratio comes from coding real married couples' interactions as positive or negative, not from a theory about why bad feels heavier. [Source 5](#)

KNOW

Stepping away doesn't mean the issue gets dropped or forgotten. In a study on couples, pausing mid-argument and returning to the same issue later led to calmer heart rates and a more positive, productive conversation.

Married couples' heart rates dropped during the pause, and when they returned to the same issue, the conversation itself became more positive and productive. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

What you say when you're truly angry is what you really think, the anger just strips away the filter.

ACTUALLY

Intense anger often exaggerates or distorts what you're seeing, more than it clears away a filter. What gets said in the heat of it isn't a **reliable sign** of what someone stably believes. [Source 7](#)

Sources

1. <https://news.osu.edu/breathe-dont-vent-turning-down-the-heat-is-key-to-managing-anger/>
2. <https://websites.umich.edu/~bbushman/PSPB02.pdf>
3. <https://faculty.wharton.upenn.edu/wp-content/uploads/2018/04/1-s2.0-S0749597816308172-main.pdf>
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7. <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/think-your-way-to-health/202508/many-a-truth-is-spoken-in-anger-or-not>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Feelings and staying level at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)